incomplete.[14]

Clearly, the shah's hospitality was designed to overawe as much as to please; and there was no end, besides, to the slights Humayun had to endure and the threats he had to evade. The shah insisted, for example, on referring to Humayun as his younger brother, although the exiled padishah was eight years his senior. Tahmasp also wanted Humayun to convert to Shiism. This was not, in itself, inimical to Humayun's religious sensibility, but it would have made him even less appealing to the chieftains of Kabul and Qandahar – all Sunni – than he was already. Several stories from this time reveal the nimble ducks and feints Humayun performed to keep his religion and his head. At their first meeting, for example, Shah Tahmasp offered his guest a *taj hyder*, a crown with veneration of the twelve Imams, integral to Shia Islam, built into its design. Humayun, most likely, was wearing a crown he'd 'invented' in Badakhshan – its distinguishing feature being the two '7s' in its design, 77 being the numerical equivalent of '*izz*', that is, 'power'. Humayun had brought this '*taj-i-izzat*' as a gift for Babur when he came uninvited to Agra years ago, and it may have helped assuage Babur's displeasure at Humayun's dereliction of duty.[15]

Now, once again, Humayun was in the court of a great monarch, one he could neither charm nor afford to displease. Humayun took the taj hyder from Tahmasp and declared that since any taj – crown – was 'an emblem of greatness',[16] he would gladly wear it as such. The taj-i-izzat, Humayun's proud invention, was quietly set aside.[17]

The shah took sadistic pleasure, it seems, in reminding Humayun of how he had lost his throne, subjecting the exiled emperor to humiliations – fining Humayun's party for letting deer escape during a hunt – and hectoring lectures: 'It was a consequence of your foolish vanity, that you could not properly govern those *extensive* dominions; you were therefore driven away by the *villagers* . . .'[18] At one point, the shah may even have thought of having his guest killed – it's unclear why – and both Jouher and Gulbadan agree that it was the shah's sister, Sultana, who saved Humayun's life 'when it was in the balance'.[19] All in all, with little to protect him from either the shah's relentless entertainment or his unpredictable moods, it is no wonder that Humayun called upon the faithful Jouher to '*champoo*' his head.[20]